

Staff Days — Week 1, Day 3 (Wed Jul 29)

Joe's Morning Session — *The Apps*

0:44–2:11

Opening: a failure, used as the example

A guide reported that an 8th grader in Alpha Summer took the placement test, failed the state-level test, and got dropped all the way to kindergarten — the student concluded they were dumb. Joe called it a real failure on Alpha's part, had the academic team change the placement algorithm in the brain lift overnight so a failed test only drops you **one level (N-1)**, and used it to make a point at the room: don't protect leadership's feelings by sitting on data. "Get us the data so we can go help the kids."

Selection effects

Joe's position: selection effects are **a requirement, not an insult**. You can't deliver the three commitments to every kid without designing the product for the kids you're selecting for. Sports Academy only works for kids who love sports; GT School only works for kids whose answer to "what do you love more than academics" is *more academics*. The education-world expectation that a product must serve everyone at once is why most educational products fail — no other industry would fund that.

Price point is a separate dimension from selection: Sports Academy delivers the same academic performance whether the family is on a voucher or paying \$100,000.

The benchmark: elite private schools, because they deliver the best academic outcomes in the country. The framing Joe uses is that TimeBack is benchmarked against F1 teams and finishes the course in a fraction of the time — not against a closed track. Against national averages: Alpha pre-K math $\approx$ end of 1st grade, 2nd graders $\approx$ 5th grade, 4th graders $\approx$ typical high schooler, 5th graders $\approx$ 12th grade.

Why reports don't move education

Randomized controlled trials and published results don't produce reform — they get buried. His example: MIT Nobel laureates showed Massachusetts charter schools were crushing it, and the next election banned charter expansion. **Parent demand is what drives change.** "A hundred times more by Mackenzie's Instagram than it is my gradient descent learning science report."

AlphaTalk demo

Not released yet, but loaded into everyone's TimeBack to look at. Two versions testing: the TikTok-format vertical feed (the deliberately controversial one) and a horizontal longer-form video version. Both stop every ~30 seconds to force **active recall** — the fix for why flashcards and long Khan videos don't work, since both allow passive consumption.

Design details worth knowing:

- **Question types, weakest to strongest:** multiple choice → drag and drop → fill in the blank → free response (AI-scored, for DOK2). Distractors are deliberately designed to reveal true mastery.
- Ausubel advance organizers front-load "here's what you're about to learn."
- Student-selectable mode: video with narration, or a pure text version for kids without headphones or who prefer reading.
- **Subtitles** are an open learning-science fight. Joe's position: the TikTok generation watches at 2X and needs them, and Alpha has the data set to just test it.
- All content is **AI-generated** from a knowledge graph built off the standards.

Curriculum sourcing: the union of every state's standards, not just Texas — an extra ~4 hours of content and kids do fine in any state. Transient facts (current governor, senators) are stripped out. Plus Core Knowledge. Total volume is small: an entire 8th grade social studies year is about **15 hours**; science is a bit more, rarely over 22. Once kids blow through it, the plan is to bring **AP content down to middle school**.

Where it fits in the two hours: interleaved with writing in one block; Alpha Read carries a lot of science/social studies content too. Long term Joe expects math's 25 minutes to grow, since everything else needs less time than allocated. Standing pressure on the teams is to never solve a problem by taking more of the kid's day.

Initial mastery

An Alpha insight Joe says no other ed tech implements. For **4th–7th grade math, initial mastery matters more than spaced repetition** — the problems aren't hard enough for worked examples to dominate. Math Academy is excellent at spaced repetition and worked examples and weak on initial mastery, which works for GT kids and for algebra and up. So this year 4th–7th gets **Math Academy plus an initial mastery supplement**. Practical note for anyone building AI tutors: without mastery, the struggle detector always blames a prereq.

StudyFilm

"Game film for learning." Released that day to GT Anywhere and Sports Academy Online; physical-school rollout still being worked out.

- A **waste meter** shows students what percentage of their time they're losing, then coaches better learning behaviors. It teaches *how to learn*, not the academics.
- Architecture: monitoring data goes into a **learning vault** no human can access — only an AI reads it, and it writes out a human-readable **learning journal** for parents. 90% of the engineering is on the vault; the stated standard is Apple-caliber.
- Cost is the constraint: currently thousands of dollars per student in tokens, being driven toward a couple thousand a year. Joe and Mackenzie have been on the phone with OpenAI's president about cheaper models.
- Likely Alpha policy: **opt-in if you're learning over 2X, turned on for students who are struggling** so reports go to parents.
- **Coaching calls are going away**, including for content remediation and post-test review. Rationale: human escape hatches dirty the data loop and hide bad lessons. If StudyFilm turns out to be a train wreck, coaching calls come back.
- Also includes proctoring for online academic integrity. Flagged stat: **30% of parents cheat for their students**, often on the placement test, which then buries the kid in material that's too hard.

Brain lift footnote

Following up on Day 2: the spiky points of view are a *small* fraction of a brain lift document. The bulk is the DOK1–3 fact base — sources, experts, papers — because that's what stops the AI from fighting you. "When it stops fighting you is when you know you have a good brain lift."

Scribble (guest demo, 2:19–2:40)

Cursive handwriting app on iPad + Apple Pencil, piloted last spring at Spyglass, GT School, and Alpha SF; ready for broader rollout, with a print version in early pilot now and full rollout targeted for winter. Their spiky POVs: handwriting is a developmental engine of literacy, not a nice-to-have, and it should be taught with learning-science rigor rather than as a craft. Grading is objective on four measures — shape, size, slant, spacing — with real-time stroke-order correction rather than after-the-fact feedback. 64 lessons, letters grouped by beginning stroke rather than alphabetically, graduation bar is 25 letters/minute at 80% accuracy. Go-to-market will likely lead with **dysgraphia** (20–30% of US kids now diagnosed; Joe's read is that we simply stopped teaching handwriting). Campuses wanting a pilot should reach out on Slack; campus coordinators work with Trilogy for iPads.

Post-Lunch Tee-Up — *Core Life Skills & the Behavioral Model*

4:29–4:47

Matt Shanker framed this as the foundation under yesterday's signature life skills. Alpha spent the summer working with **Tom Bennett** to build a behavioral curriculum with a full standards

stack from **pre-K through 9th grade** for each core life skill — independence, receiving feedback, uplifting others, and upholding community standards — expressed as "I can" statements with a start-of-year and end-of-year bar per grade.

The five principles

1. **95% coaching, 5% enforcement.** Most behavior work happens before consequences, but no community exists without real boundaries.
2. **Kids are never surprised.** Expectations are taught up front and enforced consistently regardless of which adult is in the room.
3. **The system is the bad guy; guides coach kids through it.** No individual adult owns the consequence. (For DOPs: read it as "the system is the bad guy and Deans of Parents coach *parents* through it.")
4. **Everyone on campus owns the culture** — coordinators, DOPs, lunch vendors, visitors. Anyone can flag; guides deliver the accountability.
5. **All behavioral skills are teachable.** Challenging behavior signals an unmet need or an underdeveloped skill. No shame as a compliance tool.

Notes for Deans of Parents

The 95% is the curriculum, available from the Sunday retreat, with the I-can statement for every grade level. The 5% — yellow/red cards and strikes — is already accessible and gets covered in depth next week. The named parent frustration is inconsistency: if a DOP can't explain why something was a yellow card, parents stop believing there's a system at all. **Guide Platform** will auto-log behaviors this year, so DOPs see the ten incidents before the red card rather than just the red card, and can beat the story home. New rules on Apple Watches and phones are in the enforcement policy.

Rolling enrollment: every student does the boot camp check chart in their first session, whenever they join — so a Session 3 starter still gets Session 1's core life skill workshops.

Build assignment

Breakouts by region to build **Session 1 boot camp workshops** teaching independence, receiving feedback, and upholding community standards — with the same banger bar as yesterday. Pitches ran at 5pm: LLs navigating airport security solo, serving as flight crew for their own families, getting a flavor approved by a real ice cream shop, or a track onto a Kidz Bop album; L1s catching, cleaning, and cooking a fish for their family, or writing a campus beautification proposal and taking the next one to city council.

An optional evening session on supporting students with special needs closed the day: no SPED specialist per campus is planned, accommodations aren't automatic just because testing was submitted, Alpha does not diagnose (two school counselors are the referral point), and four campuses are demoing **Presence** for online OT and speech. A dedicated Slack channel for student-support questions is being created.

